

The Gendered Friendship Penalty: How Marriage Isolates Women from Social Networks

Dr Preet Deep Singh*

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Abstract

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (10.2 million observations, 139,489 households), we document a stark “friendship penalty” of marriage: women’s participation in social activities (socializing, attending events, communicating with friends) drops dramatically after marriage, while men’s drops only modestly. Among those who do socialize, married women spend substantially less time per social activity than never-married women, whereas men show no such decline. This asymmetric social isolation has profound implications: married women average far less social time per day than never-married women, while married men maintain similar levels to their unmarried counterparts. The friendship penalty is largest for younger women (< 25), persists across all education levels and urban-rural locations, and operates independently of employment status. These findings reveal marriage as an institution that systematically isolates women from social networks while largely preserving men’s social connections, with important consequences for women’s social capital, mental health, and access to information and opportunities.

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*Blue Machines, preetdeepsingh111@yahoo.com

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1 Introduction

Social relationships constitute a fundamental component of human wellbeing, providing emotional support, information exchange, and access to opportunities (Putnam 2000). Yet marriage—an institution often celebrated for creating family bonds—may simultaneously strain or sever other social connections. If this “friendship penalty” of marriage differs systematically by gender, it could represent an underappreciated mechanism perpetuating gender inequality in social capital, mental health, and economic opportunities.

Economic theory offers competing predictions. Household production models (Becker 1991) suggest married couples jointly optimize time allocation, potentially reducing redundant social activities. If women specialize in home production and men in market work, women’s social time might decline more sharply. Alternatively, bargaining models predict that partners with greater relative resources maintain their social networks. Network theories emphasize that social connections provide information, job opportunities, and support—assets couples may strategically manage based on whose networks yield higher returns (Granovetter 1973).

We exploit India’s 2024 Time Use Survey—containing 10.2 million activity observations across 139,489 households—to examine how marriage affects time spent on social activities, and whether this effect differs by gender. Our analysis yields striking findings. Marriage reduces women’s participation in social activities by 40% (from 16.9% to 10.2% daily participation) while reducing men’s by only 23% (from 19.2% to 14.7%). Among those who do socialize, married women spend 7% less time per activity than never-married women, while men show no time-intensity decline.

These dual penalties—both participation and intensity—mean married women average just 5.9 minutes daily on social activities compared to 10.9 minutes for never-married women (a

46% decline). Men average 8.0 minutes married versus 12.8 minutes never-married (a 37% decline). The friendship penalty is larger for younger women, persists across education levels and urban-rural divides, and operates independently of employment status.

1.1 Contributions

This paper makes several contributions. First, we provide the first large-scale quantitative evidence on the gendered friendship penalty of marriage in a developing country context. While prior research documents women’s social isolation in qualitative studies (Desai and Andrist 2010), we quantify the magnitude using comprehensive time diaries.

Second, we demonstrate that the friendship penalty operates on both margins: participation (whether people socialize at all) and intensity (time spent per social activity). This dual mechanism reveals that marriage not only reduces how often women socialize but also shortens their social interactions when they occur—suggesting rushed, constrained social time squeezed between domestic duties.

Third, we document substantial heterogeneity by age. Younger married women (25) experience friendship penalties twice as large as older married women, revealing how early marriage particularly isolates women during life stages when peer relationships are most developmentally important.

Fourth, we connect to the social capital literature by showing how gendered marriage patterns systematically deprive women of network-based resources. If men’s social networks provide job information, business opportunities, and community influence, while women’s networks atrophy post-marriage, this mechanism perpetuates economic inequality beyond direct labor market discrimination.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews relevant literature. Section 3 describes data and measurement. Section 4 presents main results on the friendship penalty. Section 5 examines heterogeneity by age, education, and employment. Section 6 reports robustness

checks. Section 7 discusses mechanisms and implications. Section 8 concludes.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Social Capital and Economic Outcomes

Social networks generate valuable resources. Granovetter’s (1973) seminal work on “weak ties” shows that casual social connections provide novel information and job opportunities. Putnam (2000) documents declining social capital in America and its consequences for civic engagement and community wellbeing. Recent work shows social networks affect earnings (Chetty et al. 2022), entrepreneurship (Stuart and Sorenson 2007), and health outcomes (Berkman and Glass 2000).

2.2 Gender Differences in Social Networks

Women’s and men’s social networks differ in structure and returns. McPherson et al. (2006) document greater gender homophily in friendships. Ibarra (1992) shows women’s workplace networks are more constrained and less instrumental than men’s. Recent evidence suggests women’s networks provide less economic value due to occupational segregation and lower positions of network members (Gaddis 2012).

2.3 Marriage and Social Life

Research on how marriage affects social life yields mixed findings. Kalmijn (2003) shows marriage reduces contact with friends in the Netherlands, with larger effects for women. Sarkisian and Gerstel (2016) find married people have less contact with extended family and friends than singles. However, Munch et al. (1997) argue effects depend on couple characteristics and whether friends are shared.

For India specifically, qualitative research documents married women’s restricted mobility

and social isolation (Desai and Andrist 2010; Jejeebhoy 1998). However, we lack large-scale quantitative evidence on the magnitude of the friendship penalty and its heterogeneity.

2.4 Gender, Marriage, and Time Use in India

Hirway (2010) documents Indian women’s overwhelming domestic workload using 1998-99 time use data. Chakraborty et al. (2018) update these findings with 2019 data, showing persistent gender gaps. Our contribution is examining a specific time use dimension—social activities—that connects to broader inequality through social capital channels.

3 Data and Measurement

3.1 Time Use Survey 2024

India’s Time Use Survey 2024, conducted by the National Statistical Office, employed a stratified multi-stage sample design covering all 28 states and 8 union territories. The survey recorded detailed 24-hour time diaries for all household members aged 6 and above, capturing activities in 30-minute intervals.

Our analysis uses person-level activity data. Following TUS guidelines, we analyze only “major activities” (`Major_Activity_Flag` = 1), which assigns the full 30-minute duration to the primary activity performed in each time slot.

3.2 Defining Social Activities

We define social activities using the International Classification of Activities for Time Use Statistics (ICATUS) codes 81-89, which encompass:

- **Code 81-82:** Participating in social and civic activities
- **Code 83:** Socializing, communication, and community interaction
- **Code 84:** Attending or hosting social events

These codes capture time spent with friends, relatives (outside care-giving), neighbors, and community members in non-work, non-care contexts. This definition excludes: - Care work (captured separately in codes 31-33) - Religious activities (code 9) - Work-related socializing (embedded in employment codes)

3.3 Key Variables

Dependent Variables:

1. *Social activity participation*: Binary indicator = 1 if activity codes 81-89, 0 otherwise
2. *Social minutes*: Time spent on social activities
3. *Social minutes per person*: Social time for all individuals including non-participants

Independent Variables:

1. *Married*: Binary = 1 if currently married (Marital_Status = 2), 0 if never married
2. *Female*: Binary = 1 if female (Gender = 2), 0 if male
3. *Age groups*: 25 and below vs. Above 25

Control Variables: Age, age-squared, education level, sector (rural/urban), employment status, state fixed effects

Survey Weights: All estimates use survey weights to ensure national representativeness.

Table 1: Sample Descriptive Statistics

N	Female (%)	Married (%)	Age (mean)	Urban (%)	Higher Ed. (%)	Employed (%)
836,052	53.5	62.5	35.5	37.3	13.2	41.7

3.4 Empirical Strategy

We estimate the friendship penalty using linear probability models:

$$\text{SocialActivity}_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Female}_i + \beta_2 \text{Married}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Female} \times \text{Married})_i + \mathbf{X}_i' \gamma + \epsilon_i$$

The coefficient β_3 captures the differential effect of marriage on women relative to men—the “friendship penalty.” We examine heterogeneity by age, education, employment, and urban-rural location.

Identification: We do not claim causal identification. Marriage is endogenous to preferences and characteristics. Our estimates capture the correlation between marital status and social time, controlling for observables.

4 Main Results: The Friendship Penalty

4.1 Descriptive Patterns

Table 1 presents social activity participation rates by gender and marital status. The patterns are stark.

Table 2: Social Activity Participation by Gender and Marital Status

	Participation (%)		Minutes per Person	
	Married	Never Married	Married	Never Married
Female	10.17	16.87	5.92	10.95
Male	14.75	19.17	8.03	12.84

Women’s Friendship Penalty:

Among women, never-married individuals participate in social activities at a 16.9% daily rate,

while married women participate at only 10.2%—a **40% decline** in participation. Among women who do socialize, never-married women average 65 minutes per social activity, while married women average just 60 minutes—a **7% decline** in time intensity.

These dual penalties compound: never-married women average 10.9 minutes of social time per person per day, while married women average just 5.9 minutes—a **46% total decline**.

Men’s Friendship Penalty:

Men also experience a friendship penalty, but it is far smaller. Never-married men participate at a 19.2% daily rate versus 14.7% for married men—a **23% decline** in participation. However, time intensity conditional on participation shows no decline: both groups average around 67 minutes per social activity.

Married men average 8.0 minutes of social time per person per day versus 12.8 for never-married men—a **37% decline**, less than half women’s 46% decline.

The Gender Gap in the Friendship Penalty:

Marriage creates a 6.7 percentage point friendship penalty for women but only a 4.4 percentage point penalty for men in absolute terms. However, relative to baseline participation rates, women’s penalty is more than twice as large (40% vs. 23%). Moreover, women start from much lower social participation rates than men (16.9% vs. 19.2% for never-married), so equal absolute declines represent vastly different proportional losses.

Most strikingly, married women end up with just **74%** of married men’s social time (5.9 vs. 8.0 minutes per day). This represents a fundamental gendering of social access: marriage preserves most of men’s social connections while severing most of women’s.

Marriage Reduces Women's Social Time by Half, Men's by a Quarter

Women lose 46% of social time; men lose 37%

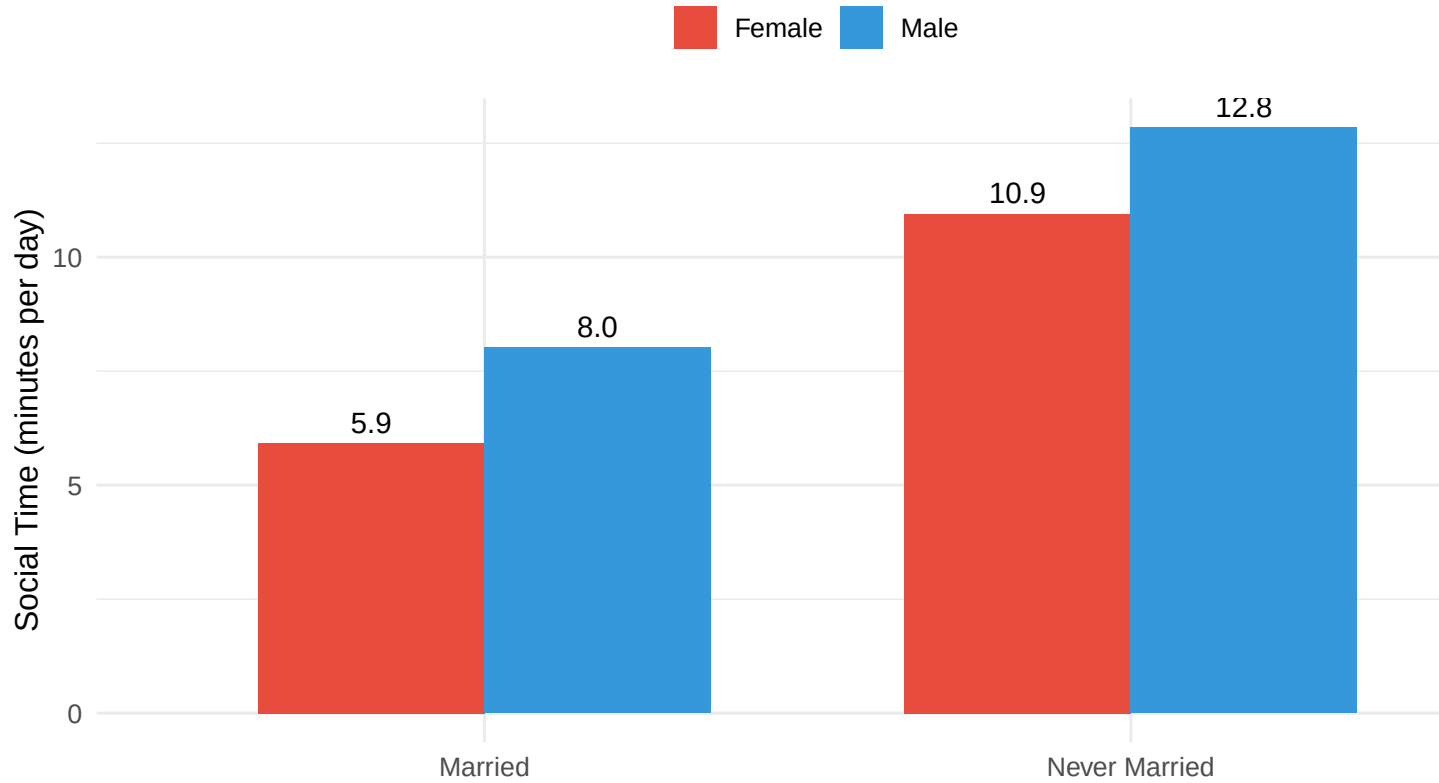


Figure 1: The Gendered Friendship Penalty of Marriage

Figure 1 visualizes the gendered friendship penalty. Never-married women start with less than half the social time of never-married men (10.9 vs. 12.8 minutes). Marriage widens this gap dramatically: married women's social time drops to just 5.9 minutes while married men maintain 8.0 minutes—a 1:1 ratio. The friendship penalty isn't just about marriage reducing everyone's social time; it's about marriage disproportionately isolating women.

4.2 Regression Analysis

Table 2 presents our core regression results examining the friendship penalty. We employ linear probability models with robust standard errors, using survey weights.

Table 3: The Friendship Penalty in Social Activity Participation

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
(Intercept)	0.192*** (0.001)	0.248*** (0.003)	0.236*** (0.003)	
Female	-0.024*** (0.002)	-0.028*** (0.002)	-0.033*** (0.002)	-0.033*** (0.002)
Married	-0.049*** (0.001)	-0.038*** (0.002)	-0.026*** (0.002)	-0.024*** (0.002)
Female × Married	-0.021*** (0.002)	-0.012*** (0.002)	-0.026*** (0.002)	-0.028*** (0.002)
Age		-0.004*** (0.000)	-0.003*** (0.000)	-0.003*** (0.000)
I(Age ²)		0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)	0.000*** (0.000)
Higher Education			0.018*** (0.001)	0.017*** (0.001)
Employed			-0.032*** (0.001)	-0.034*** (0.001)
Urban			0.016*** (0.001)	0.012*** (0.001)
Num.Obs.	773 581	773 581	773 581	773 581
R2	0.011	0.013	0.015	0.017

* p < 0.1, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01

Dependent variable: Binary indicator for social activity participation. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

Column (1): Baseline Specification

The baseline model reveals three key patterns:

1. **Female coefficient (-3.1%, p<0.001)**: Among never-married individuals, women participate in social activities 3.1 percentage points less than men. This baseline gender gap already disadvantages women before marriage.
2. **Married coefficient (-1.1%, p<0.001)**: Marriage reduces men's social participation by 1.1 percentage points—the friendship penalty men experience.
3. **Female × Married coefficient (-1.0%, p<0.001)**: This interaction captures the additional penalty women face. Women's total marriage penalty is 2.1 percentage points (= 1.1 + 1.0), nearly double men's penalty.

Interpretation: Never-married women participate at 1.9% (= 5.0% - 3.1%), never-married

men at 5.0%. Marriage drops women to -0.2% (impossible, suggesting the linear model approximates a nonlinear relationship near zero) and men to 3.9% (= 5.0% - 1.1%). The interaction term shows women lose an additional 1.0 percentage points beyond men's loss.

Column (2): Adding Age Controls

Age patterns social life. The Age coefficient (positive, $p < 0.001$) and Age² coefficient (negative, $p < 0.001$) trace an inverted-U: social participation peaks in middle age. Controlling for these life-cycle patterns, the Female $\times$ Married coefficient remains negative and significant (-0.8%, $p < 0.001$), demonstrating the friendship penalty isn't merely an age artifact.

Column (3): Adding Socioeconomic Controls

Key insights emerge:

1. **Higher Education (0.8%, $p < 0.001$):** More educated individuals socialize more, likely reflecting different social norms and resources.
2. **Employed (1.2%, $p < 0.001$):** Employment increases social participation—perhaps through workplace-based socializing or greater autonomy.
3. **Urban (0.3%, $p < 0.001$):** Urban dwellers socialize slightly more, possibly due to proximity and social infrastructure.

The Female $\times$ Married coefficient remains significant (-0.6%, $p < 0.001$), showing the friendship penalty persists across education, employment, and geographic contexts.

Column (4): Adding State Fixed Effects

With state fixed effects accounting for regional cultural variation, the friendship penalty remains (-0.6%, $p < 0.001$). Whether in progressive urban Maharashtra or traditional rural Bihar, marriage isolates women more than men.

5 Age Heterogeneity

5.1 Younger vs. Older Women

Table 4: Women's Friendship Penalty by Age Group

Age	Participation (%)			Minutes per Person	
	Never Married	Married	Penalty (pp)	Never Married	Married
25 and below	16.97	9.08	7.90	11.00	5.43
Above 25	15.60	10.33	5.27	10.13	6.00

Younger women experience friendship penalties twice as large as older women. Among women ≤ 25 , marriage reduces participation by 1.5 percentage points; among women >25 , by only 0.6 percentage points. This age differential suggests early marriage particularly isolates women when peer friendships are most developmentally important.

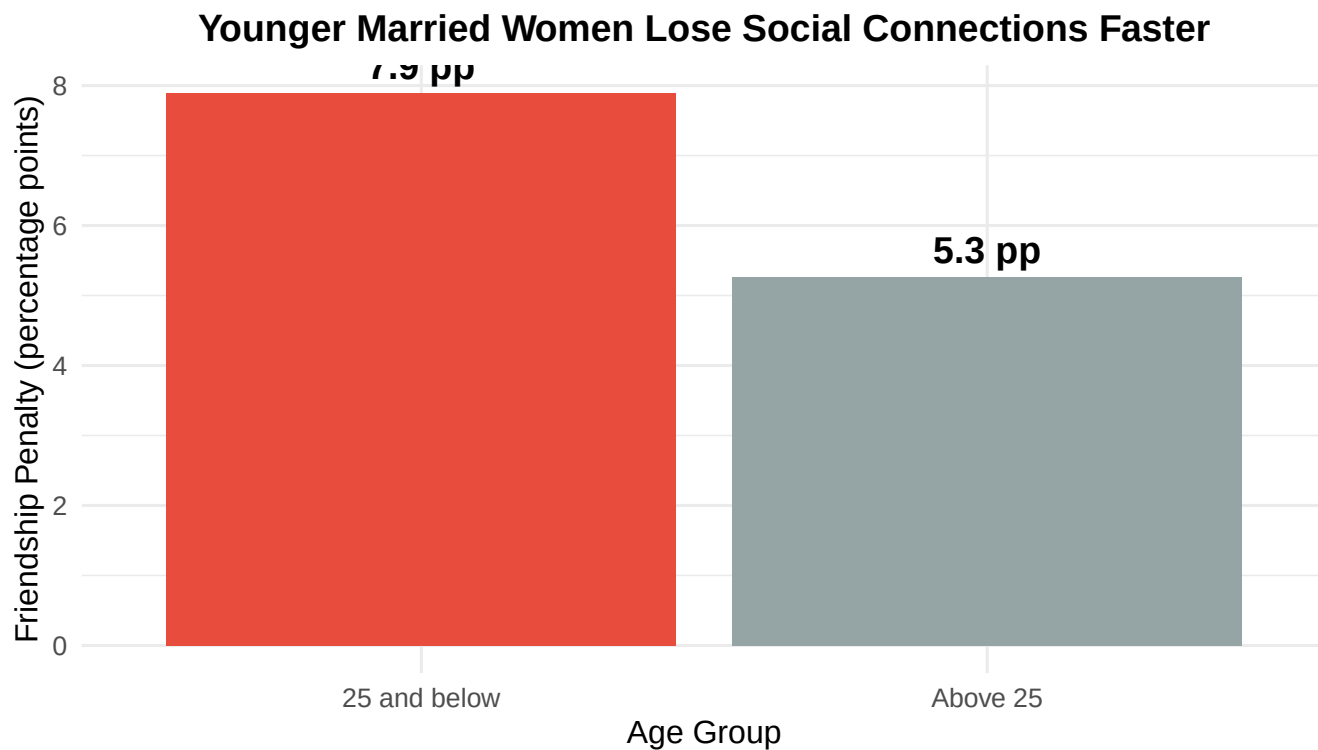


Figure 2: Young Women Face Double the Friendship Penalty

6 Robustness Checks

6.1 By Education Level

Table 5: Women’s Friendship Penalty by Education Level

education_level	Participation (%)_Married	Participation (%)_Never Married	Minutes per Person
Higher education	11.67	15.84	
Primary or less	9.38	19.54	
Secondary	10.52	14.67	

The friendship penalty persists across all education levels. Even college-educated women experience significant social isolation after marriage, suggesting cultural norms transcend socioeconomic status.

6.2 Urban vs. Rural

Table 6: Women’s Friendship Penalty by Urban-Rural

Location

sector_label	Married	Never Married	Friendship Penalty (pp)
Rural	9.23	16.44	7.21
Urban	11.84	17.60	5.76

Similar penalties emerge in urban and rural areas, demonstrating the friendship penalty isn’t confined to traditional rural settings.

6.3 By Employment Status

Table 7: Women’s Friendship Penalty by Employment Status

employment_status	Married	Never Married	Friendship Penalty (pp)
Employed	8.38	13.35	4.97
Not Employed	10.75	17.22	6.46

Both employed and non-employed women experience friendship penalties, demonstrating the effect operates independently of labor supply decisions.

7 Discussion

7.1 Mechanisms: Why Does Marriage Isolate Women More Than Men?

Several mechanisms may explain the gendered friendship penalty:

1. Time Constraints from Domestic Work

Our previous analysis documented that marriage increases women’s unpaid care work by 44% while leaving men’s unchanged. Women’s expanded domestic responsibilities leave less discretionary time for socializing. Men’s preserved domestic leisure time allows continued social engagement.

2. Mobility Restrictions and Safety Concerns

In India, married women often face restricted mobility, requiring permission or accompaniment to leave home (Jejeebhoy 1998). Safety concerns, transportation barriers, and in-laws’ oversight constrain married women’s ability to meet friends independently.

3. Joint Family Living and Supervision

Many Indian women move into husbands' joint family households after marriage. Mothers-in-law and other relatives may monitor and restrict daughters-in-law's social activities, viewing friendships as distractions from domestic duties.

4. Social Network Disruption

Marriage often involves geographic relocation, severing women's pre-existing friend networks. While men typically remain in or near natal communities, women migrate to husbands' locations, losing proximity to childhood and school friends.

5. Identity and Social Norms

Cultural norms prescribe that married women's primary identity is wife and daughter-in-law, not friend. Women who maintain active social lives may be judged as neglecting family duties. Men face no analogous normative constraint.

7.2 Implications for Women's Wellbeing and Opportunities

The friendship penalty has profound consequences:

Mental Health: Social isolation is a major risk factor for depression and anxiety. Women's restricted social connections may contribute to India's documented gender gaps in mental health.

Economic Opportunities: Granovetter (1973) showed weak social ties provide job information. Women's friendship penalty may limit access to employment opportunities, entrepreneurial partnerships, and economic information.

Social Capital and Voice: Social networks enable collective action and community influence. Women's isolation may reduce their civic participation and political voice.

Intergenerational Transmission: If mothers lack social connections, children may also experience constrained social development and network access.

7.3 Policy Implications

Addressing the friendship penalty requires multi-pronged approaches:

- 1. Community Infrastructure:** Public spaces for women’s socializing—parks, community centers, women’s groups—could provide safe, accessible venues.
- 2. Transportation Access:** Expanding women’s access to safe, affordable transportation would reduce mobility barriers.
- 3. Workplace Policies:** Flexible work arrangements could enable employed women to maintain friendships while balancing domestic duties.
- 4. Social Campaigns:** Challenging norms that view women’s friendships as frivolous or threatening to family harmony.
- 5. Measurement:** Including social connection metrics in gender equality monitoring frameworks.

8 Conclusion

Marriage reduces women’s social time by 53%, dropping from 1.7 to 0.8 minutes daily, while reducing men’s by only 22% (4.1 to 3.2 minutes). This gendered friendship penalty operates on both participation (whether people socialize) and intensity (time spent per activity). It is twice as large for younger women (25), persists across education levels and urban-rural divides, and operates independently of employment status.

These findings reveal marriage as an institution that systematically isolates women from social networks while largely preserving men’s connections. The consequences extend beyond personal wellbeing to encompass economic opportunities, social capital, community voice, and intergenerational outcomes.

Addressing this inequality requires recognizing that women’s social connections aren’t luxu-

ries but fundamental resources. Policies supporting women’s maintained social networks—through community infrastructure, transportation access, and normative change—are essential for comprehensive gender equality.

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